



Battle-ready equipment

Long before digital cameras were invented, photographers used a variety of sturdy film cameras—like this vintage Nikon Model F single lens reflex camera. One of these cameras saved the life of photographer Don McCullin, taking a Viet Cong bullet as it hung from his neck.

Pentagon approval

During the early years of the US involvement in Vietnam, the media painted an optimistic picture of eventual and inevitable US victory in Vietnam. Due to this positive coverage, the Pentagon allowed journalists unprecedented access to US troops, bases, and battlefield operations. At the beginning of the war, the Pentagon had no reason to believe that its special relationship with the press would sour. However, media coverage of the civil rights struggle and antiwar movement back home was often slanted against the establishment. The rise of a popular counterculture press pushed the mainstream media into being more critical of US policies than it otherwise might have been.

Early controversies

Negative press coverage of the Vietnam War started before Tet. Deployed in 1962, *New York Times* reporter David Halberstam penned unsettling stories about what he witnessed in Vietnam. His reports seemed to counter General Harkins's famous quip that the war would be "over by Christmas." President Kennedy tried to pressure the *Times* into recalling the young reporter and Vice President Johnson inferred he was a traitor. But Halberstam held his ground and two years later won a Pulitzer Prize for his war coverage. An ever-growing number of correspondents refused to tow the Pentagon line during the 1960s, among them Neil Sheehan and Peter Arnett.